Mastering Observability

ADVISORY · STRATEGY · PRACTICE

COMPANION WORKBOOK · METRICS & MAYHEM

# The Signal Audit: thirty minutes, one incident, yours.

A working companion to Metrics & Mayhem. Five short audits of your own last incident, and the ninety-day plan that comes out of them.

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FREE COMPANION WORKBOOK · THE ONLY NUMBERS YOU ADD ARE YOUR OWN · SOURCES ARE CHAPTERS 5, 6, 8 AND 11 AND APPENDICES B AND C OF THE BOOK

AT A GLANCE · HOW TO USE THIS

# One honest reconstruction of your own last incident.

This is not a culture survey. It is one honest reconstruction of your own last incident, done by you, before you ask anyone else to do it.

Five short audits and a plan. Each audit takes your most recent real Sev1 or Sev2 and finds the thing your tooling did not capture: the hunch that stayed unsaid, the blame in the first five minutes, the capability you paid for and did not build, the behaviour you reward without meaning to. The plan at the end turns what you found into ninety days.

Do it on the last real incident. Not a hypothetical. Write the answers down; a thought you do not write down is a thought you get to pretend you had.

02 **Your real time to truth goes unmeasured**
The gap between the thought and the words is one no dashboard shows.

03 **The first five minutes show your culture**
Whether the bridge goes looking for a cause or for a person.

04 **Capability lives in a few heads**
Count who could investigate a novel incident on your most critical service alone.

05 **What gets recognised repeats**
Visible saves get thanked; quiet prevention gets nothing unless you name it.

06 **Findings change nothing without names**
Five names and dates turn the audits into a quarter's plan.

| 01 | 02 + 03 | 04 | 05 | 06 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| The quick read | Silence, blame | Capability | Recognition | Ninety days |

HOW THIS WAS SOURCED

Chapters 5, 6, 8 and 11 and Appendices B and C of Metrics & Mayhem, and the author's own experience, with details changed so no organisation can be identified. No vendor surveys. The only numbers you add are your own.

SECTION 01 · THE SELF-ASSESSMENT

# 01 Your last bridge was quieter than you think

Thursday, 14:22. A junior engineer sees a payment completion rate drop from 99.2% to 97.8%. She checks the deployment log. A configuration change shipped twenty minutes ago. She thinks it might be the cause. She says nothing on the incident channel for eleven minutes, because the last time she flagged something, the VP of Engineering asked "who approved this?" in a tone that made everyone go quiet.

That scene opens Chapter 6 of the book. Before you audit the parts, get an honest read on the whole.

THE QUICK READ · ONE WORD EACH, FIRST INSTINCT

01 On your last incident, could the person nearest the cause say so without it costing them? Yes or no.

02 Did your first five minutes go looking for a cause, or for a person? Cause or person.

03 Do the engineers you pay to use your observability tools actually use them, or have three people become the ones who always investigate? Used or hoarded.

04 When someone surfaces a problem early and is right, does anything good visibly happen to them? Yes or no.

05 If the same incident happened next week, would your team be faster? Yes or no.

### What this tells you

Count your "no", "person", and "hoarded" answers. Each one is a section of this workbook you should not skip. Zero of them and you are the rare exception; do the audits anyway, because the gap between what a leader believes about their culture and what their last bridge did is almost always wider than the leader thinks.

**What you just found**

Capability lives in a small number of heads, and you can now count them. You cannot post your way out of this gap. It closes in the work, incident by incident, over months. The number in step 1 is the one to grow, and step 5 is where you start.

SECTION 04 · THE 30-DAY TRACKER

## Count the thinking, not the seats

For the next thirty days, track one number: how many different engineers touched the observability stack in a way that required thinking, not just looking. A dashboard built. An SLO defined. A question instrumented in a review. Write the count at the end of each week.

| WEEK | ENGINEERS WHO DID THE THINKING WORK | WHAT THEY DID |
|---|---|---|
| Week 1 | | |
| Week 2 | | |
| Week 3 | | |
| Week 4 | | |

Four numbers. If they do not move, the practice is not embedded yet, and no course will embed it.

> **On Monday.** Take the engineer from step 5 and pair them, this week, with the outcome rather than the service. Not "own the checkout service". "Own explaining the payment completion rate." When accountability includes a business outcome, people start asking different questions of their data.

SECTION 06 · THE NINETY DAYS

# One quarter needs five names

WRITE THE NAME, THEN THE DATE

01 Name one outcome. From the VP conversation, the single business outcome you will make your team able to explain and own. One. Not a portfolio.

02 Name one owner. Not the team. The person who owns that outcome end to end. This is Appendix C.

03 Name one thing you will make safe. From the silence and first-five-minutes audits, the one change to your bridge that makes early truth cheaper. Commit a date.

04 Name one capability you will build. From the capability audit, the one pairing or review cadence you will run for a quarter, and who tracks the number.

05 Name one behaviour you will reward. From the recognition audit, the quiet prevention you will recognise publicly, and how often.

| COMMITMENT | NAME | DATE | HOW YOU WILL KNOW |
|---|---|---|---|
| Outcome | | | |
| Owner | | | |
| Made safe | | | |
| Capability | | | |
| Recognised | | | |

Five names. One quarter. Put them in the Appendix B scorecard, by hand, with dates, and review it in ninety days against the numbers your own audits gave you.

METRICS & MAYHEM

THE FULL GUIDE

# Get the full guide, free.

Five short audits of your own last incident, and the ninety-day plan that comes out of them.

GET IT AT

**masteringobservability.com/ebooks/signal-audit**

**Free. The link is in the first comment.**

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